

University of Texas Rio Grande Valley

Fiscal Sponsor: The University of Texas Rio Grande Valley Foundation

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What are you seeking WKKF funding to accomplish?

The issue: The Lower Rio Grande Valley of deep South Texas is considered one of the most productive agricultural regions in the country, leading Texas in fruit and vegetable production and ranking as the national leader in grains (sorghum). The region is also home to four of the largest land ports in the country—for example, the Pharr International Bridge is the #1 produce gateway in the country, with more than \$33 billion in trade in 2020. However, prosperity from food and agriculture in the RGV is unevenly distributed, with community-facing, family farms facing daunting challenges to stay viable, farm and food-worker injustices persisting, and rates of food insecurity and diet-related diseases among the highest nationwide. According to the 2017 and 2022 Census of Agriculture, Hidalgo and Cameron Counties lost 16.1% and 12.0% of all farms, respectively, and 14.2% and 23.1% of farmland, ranking among the highest declines across the US in the past 5 years. South Texas is the paradoxical home to some of the highest rates of food-related diseases, food insecurity, and poverty in the country, making our projects, negotiations, and recommendations for improving food systems—across access to capital, farmworker rights, health and nutrition, and the economy -- just as relevant here as anywhere else in the country. Given these polarizing characteristics of food and agriculture in the RGV, the region is considered by many to be the most disconnected and critically endangered food system in the country.

How to address the issue: The University of Texas Rio Grande Valley (UTRGV) Center for Sustainable Agriculture and Rural Advancement (SARA) and the Sentli Center for Regenerative Agriculture seek support to help build fair and sustainable food systems in Texas' Lower Rio Grande Valley (LRGV).

Over the past decade, SARA has been at the forefront of the regional food system by empowering existing and beginning farmers with the technical knowledge and resources needed to participate equitably in the local economy, including: expanding community-based food infrastructure to increase access to fresh, sustainably grown produce; building strategic partnerships across the food system; and educating families on healthy eating habits and the benefits of local foods. Efforts include: a recently-launched urban farm that serves as an accessible demonstration and training site for restorative agriculture and community food systems; collaborative research with UTRGV faculty focused on equitable access to energy and on farm resources; a beginning farmer program focused on food production in schools, local colonias, and rural areas; the development of the RGV Food System advisory group and the genesis of the RGV Food Systems Vision, a collaborative living document created to guide new and ongoing efforts to build, amplify, and synergize work across the region around food and agriculture; and the facilitation of the annual food summit conference intended to jumpstart genuine conversations and new approaches to sustainable and fair food systems. The last two examples were supported by a previous grant from WKKF.

In this project, SARA will collaborate with the Sentli Center for Regenerative Agriculture through the following integrated initiatives: (a) Farmer Training, Technical Assistance, and Workforce Development; (b) Building Local Food Infrastructure and Expanding Market Access for local area producers and beginning farmers and growers; (c) Expanding Equitable Access to Fresh, Healthy Foods for school-age children and their families; and (d) Health and Nutrition Education & Community Engagement. We will do this through community-based participatory workshops centered on the Hub of Prosperity Farms and the Sentli Center for Regenerative Agriculture, as well as outreach activities in the community (as detailed below).

UTRGV SARA and Sentli are deeply committed to community engagement, partnering with residents, farmers, schools, and organizations to strengthen the regional food system and expand equitable access to healthy foods. Through bilingual outreach, hands-on workshops, and mobile training delivered via the Mobile Agroecology Learning Lab, SARA and Sentli meet community

members where they are—on farms, at schools, at community centers, and in neighborhoods across the RGV. Farmers are directly involved through apprenticeship programs, incubator farm opportunities, farmers’ markets, and technical assistance that help them build viable enterprises and connect with new markets. Community organizations collaborate to develop new market sites, implement federal nutrition incentive programs, and host regional trainings that support families’ access to fresh produce. Families engage through farm visits, cooking demonstrations, and Farm-to-Family Food Festivals that celebrate local food culture while building practical skills. By creating accessible platforms for training, shared learning, and community engagement, the project ensures that community voices, needs, and strengths drive every aspect of the work. Both partners are well respected in this space for their platform of culturally and regionally relevant engagement. This funding will help them amplify their overlapping missions to advance a more resilient, just, and community-centered food system by empowering local farmers, increasing access to healthy food for students and their communities, and strengthening the socio-economic and environmental well-being of the Rio Grande Valley.

Anticipated results: By the end of the project period, we hope to continue our progress in developing a new narrative on the intersection of food, health, and prosperity in the region. This proposed program aims to deliver the following:

Farmer Training, Technical Assistance, and Workforce Development

- Provide comprehensive technical assistance, hands-on training, and access to resources for beginning and under-resourced farmers through (a) apprenticeship programs and monthly training sessions at two RGV sites—the Hub of Prosperity and the Sentli Center Farm in Edinburg, TX—and (b) outreach through the Mobile Agroecology Learning Lab (MALL), which delivers on-site training to community partners across the Valley.
- Deliver at least 10 on-site trainings on conservation agriculture and sustainable farming practices (at the Hub of Prosperity and at Sentli), and additional off-site training via the Mobile Agroecology Learning Lab offered to community partners across the Rio Grande Valley. Topics will include, but are not limited to, drip irrigation and water management; canning and food preservation; composting and cover cropping for soil health; integrated pest management; and small-scale animal husbandry. All recruitment will be conducted in both English and Spanish, with live Spanish interpretation provided during workshops. A minimum of 20 participants will complete the program, and upon completing at least 10 hours (or five sessions), will be eligible to receive a university-issued certificate from UTRGV’s Office for Professional Education and Workforce Development. This certificate program is designed to provide education and training that can enhance employability in food and agriculture-related careers or help limited-resource producers demonstrate competencies that qualify them for or enable them to compete for funding, loans, or other resources from both private and governmental sources.
- Provide access to land, water, and farm tools for at least five small-scale farmers at the Hub of Prosperity incubator farm, enabling them to launch viable farm enterprises. Farmers are invited to participate in farmers’ markets or in other market opportunities outlined below.

Building Local Food Infrastructure and Expanding Market Access

- Facilitate connections between farmers and growers in communities across the Rio Grande Valley to fresh food markets in low-access and low-income areas. Existing farmers’ markets and CSA (Community Supported Agriculture) programs, and wholesale markets to schools and other buyers, ultimately will increase access to healthy fresh produce for low-income neighborhoods, school-age children, and their families.
- Continue operations at farmers markets at both the Hub of Prosperity and Sentli Center, serving over 500 families annually. Host at least 40 farmers’ markets annually across the two sites. The outreach coordinator will help collect basic information on participants in civic agriculture, either through a real-time survey (administered on-site) or through other modes, to help us expand access to local foods.

- Prioritize sourcing from beginning and limited-resource farmers for the CSA program, with at least eight local producers selling to the CSA annually. This will increase the diversity and availability of healthy food options for low-income families within Sentli's distribution area, covering 5 cities along the Rio Grande Valley.
- Provide one-on-one technical assistance to at least 10 limited-resource farmers on wholesale readiness and marketing strategies to better position them for institutional buyers. These efforts align with Sentli's current Growing Justice Project, "Regenerate RGV," to create new farm-to-school pathways for BIPOC small- and mid-sized farmers through collective marketing and distribution while increasing the amount of fresh, nutrient-dense produce on the lunch plates of low-income children.

Expanding Equitable Access to Fresh, Healthy Foods

- Offer technical assistance to at least five local community centers interested in developing farmers' markets and implementing federal nutrition incentive programs that promote healthy eating and support local farmers. At least one location can pilot a program to coordinate a farmers' market featuring local produce and local entrepreneurs.
- Host at least one regional training session for community organizations on implementing nutrition incentive programs, including the WIC Farmers Market Nutrition Program (which provides \$30 in annual vouchers for fresh produce) and the Double Up Food Bucks Texas program, which matches SNAP benefits up to \$30/day for fruits and vegetables. These programs significantly increase families' ability to purchase nutritious produce and help remunerate local farmers who grow healthy, organic food. This session could be held on-site or at the Annual RGV Food Summit (to be offered in April 2026).
- Ensure that the Sentli Farmers Market accepts SNAP and participates in Double Up Food Bucks, enabling at least 30 families to use the program to purchase fresh, healthy foods. We will also explore the possibility of accepting SNAP at the Hub of Prosperity Farm.

Health and Nutrition Education & Community Engagement

- Implement health and nutrition education programs for children and families through farm visits, hands-on learning, and cooking demonstrations at the Hub of Prosperity and Sentli farms. Research shows that combining access to fresh produce with cooking education and opportunities to grow or harvest food helps families overcome knowledge barriers and increases vegetable consumption across age groups.
- Host 3 Farm-to-Family Food Festivals (4F) over the project period to foster community connections and teach at least 100 individuals how to prepare and promote healthy meals using local produce.
- Use the Mobile Agroecology Learning Lab to provide outreach at four schools or community centers in Hidalgo and Cameron Counties, distributing culturally relevant recipes, nutrition-incentive information, and market access guides, as well as information on educational and professional development opportunities. At least 80 individuals will learn where and how to purchase fresh, local produce.
- Publish educational materials on nutrition, agroecology, and market access on the Agroecology website (rgvagroecology.com), with at least 50 site visits annually.

Beneficiaries. Our target audience includes (a) local farmers, growers, and enterprises focused on improving production and local access to food, (b) students and faculty at UTRGV working with SARA and its partners, and (c) school-age children who attend local area schools that interact with this program.

As suggested above, conversations about reconciling the disproportionate prosperity of the RGV food system with broader access to healthy food, socio-economic prosperity, and environmental well-being must be centered on genuine inclusion of multiple voices, viewpoints, and skill sets. With support from this grant, SARA will work closely with the Sentli Center for Regenerative Agriculture (and its members and respective audiences) to leverage their capacities, reputation, and community trust to put the activities included here into action.

Share with us how you know your project will work.

Our project is grounded in proven strategies, strong community partnerships, and a track record of success that demonstrates our ability to strengthen the regional food system in the Lower Rio Grande Valley (LRGV). The proposed initiatives —farmer training, incubator farm access, community-based markets, nutrition incentive programs, and hands-on food education—are strategies with a well-documented record of success in improving food security, increasing farmer viability, and strengthening local food economies.

The University of Texas Rio Grande Valley's Center for Sustainable Agriculture and Rural Advancement (SARA) and the Sentli Center for Regenerative Agriculture have long-standing relationships with farmers, families, schools, and community organizations across the region. These relationships ensure that our work is not only culturally relevant but also directly shaped by the needs and priorities of the communities we serve.

Both SARA and Sentli have already demonstrated the effectiveness of their approaches:

- The Hub of Prosperity and Sentli Center farms have trained hundreds of residents through bilingual workshops, apprenticeships, and community events.
- Sentli's CSA program and farmers markets have connected local producers to stable, values-aligned markets and increased access to fresh produce for families across five cities.
- The Mobile Agroecology Learning Lab (MALL) has proven its ability to reach communities with limited transportation access, bringing training, demonstrations, and educational materials directly to neighborhoods, schools, and community centers.
- Sentli's Growing Justice Project has begun building farm-to-school pathways, demonstrating the feasibility of expanding institutional markets for BIPOC and limited-resource farmers.

These successes provide a strong foundation for scaling our work through this grant.

In short, we know this project will work because it builds on proven strategies, leverages trusted partnerships, directly addresses community needs, and includes clear metrics for success. With support from the W.K. Kellogg Foundation, we can scale and accelerate a model that is already working—one that advances food sovereignty, prosperity, and health equity for families across the Rio Grande Valley.